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LUCKNOW | Miles to Go

Rahul Gandhi may be the man given credit for the Congress' improved performance in the Lok Sabha elections in Uttar Pradesh, but his magic didn't work in the state by-polls. Last week's Assembly contest in four constituencies in the BSP bastion was the first test of the Congress general secretary's much-hyped "Mission 2012". But when the results arrived, the Congress figured nowhere. Worse still, two of its candidates forfeited their security deposits as the BSP swept the polls, winning three seats. In Mahilabad, the Congress got just 13.98 per cent of the vote; in Vidhuna only 10.44 per cent while it was washed out in Jat-dominated Morna with just 3.98 per cent of the vote. State Congress chief Rita Bahuguna-Joshi was quick to attribute the party's defeat to Mayawati's "misuse of official machinery". Despite the damning verdict, some may still pin their hopes on Gandhi Jr. The latest to merge with the Congress is the People's Democratic Front (PDF). Formerly called the All-India Muslim Forum, the PDF is the largest Muslim party in the state, formed in the aftermath of the Babri Masjid demolition. "The time for a rethink has arrived," says PDF chief Salauddin Khan. "The Congress under a new leadership is fighting for the same causes the Muslim forum cherished." Clearly, the voters of Uttar Pradesh think differently.

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IN THE STATE'S
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by Farzand Ahmed

3.98

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